NATIONAL ASSEMBLY, 7TH PARLIAMENT

PARLIAMENTARY STANDING COMMITTEE ON HUMAN RESOURCES AND COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT

REPORT ON THE MOTION ON ERECTING AN EVER-LIGHTING SHRINE AT VAALGRAS TO HONOUR KAPTEIN HENDRIK WITBOOI

REPORT NO. 2 OF 2025

Table of Contents

MANDATE OF THE COMMITTEE iii
COMPOSITION OF THE COMMITTEE iv
1. INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND 1
2. TERMS OF REFERENCE (TOR) 1
3. METHODOLOGY 2
4. HARDAP REGION 2
5. //KHARAS REGION 3
6. FINDINGS 5
7. CONCLUSION 5
8. RECOMMENDATIONS 5
9. SIGNATURE 6

MANDATE OF THE COMMITTEE

The mandate of the Committee is derived from Article 59 of the Namibian Constitution as well as Rule 74 (1) of the Standing Rules and Orders and Internal Arrangements of the National Assembly. The Committee must consider, examine and enquire on any matter it deems relevant about the following category of affairs which includes, among others;

- Higher Education, Training and Innovation
- Education, Arts and Culture
- Urban and Rural Development
- Sport, Youth and National Service
- Labour, Industrial Relations and Employment Creation

and may for that purpose consult and liaise with relevant institutions;

a) liaise with NGOs, Agencies and Institutions to enquire and monitor programmes that are aimed at uplifting the social and economic conditions of communities;
b) monitor and enquire into all matters related to human resource development;
c) monitor and enquire into all matters related to the development of both rural and urban communities;
d) monitor and enquire into all matters related to the needs of the youth;
e) promote harmonious industrial relations in Namibia;
f) review and advise the National Assembly on the housing needs of the people;
g) enquire into and monitor international protocols, conventions and agreements that may affect the county's human resources and community development and where necessary make recommendations to the Assembly; and
h) perform such other functions, tasks, and duties relating to Parliamentary supervision of such Offices, Ministries, Agencies or State-Owned Enterprises and Parastatals as may be prescribed by the Assembly or in terms of an Act of Parliament.

COMPOSITION OF THE COMMITTEE

Hon. Nono Katjingisiua, MP
Committee Chairperson

Hon. Tjekero Tweya, MP

Hon. Bertha Dinyando, MP

Hon. Winnie Moongo, MP

Hon. Maximalliant Katjimune, MP

Hon. Gotthard Kandume, MP

Hon. Utaara Mootu, MP

Hon. Dr. Becky Ndjoze-Ojo, MP

Hon. Natangwe Ithete, MP

Hon. Ephraim Nekongo, MP

Hon. Longinus Iipumbu, MP

Hon. Agnes Tjiramba, MP

Hon. Katrina Benz, MP

Hon. Elifas Dingara, MP
Deputy Chairperson

Hon. Agnes Mpingana Kafula, MP

Hon. Elma Dienda, MP

Hon. Yvette Araes, MP

Hon. Johanna Kandjimi, MP

Hon. Annakletha Sikerete

Hon. Maria Kamutali, MP

Hon. Herlinde Lucia Tjiveze, MP

Hon. Diederik Vries, MP

Hon. Hidipo Hamata, MP

Hon. Bernadus Swartbooi, MP

Hon. Loide Iipinge, MP

Hon. Aina Hanganeni Kodi, MP

1. INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND

1.1. In 2023, a Motion proposing the erection of an ever-lighting shrine at Vaalgras in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi was tabled in the National Assembly. The erection of the shrine at Vaalgras would serve as a perpetual beacon for Namibians, signifying remembrance and inspiration. It would offer more than just a mere commemoration and it will contribute to a nation-building agenda that is pivotal for modern Namibia.

1.2. Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi was Chief of the |Howesin people, a sub-tribe of the Nama clans. He was educated by German (Rhenish) missionaries and spoke many languages, including Khoikhoi and Dutch. He was a military strategist who led his people in armed resistance during their revolts against the German colonial empire in present-day Namibia, in connection with the events surrounding the Herero and Nama Genocide. He was instrumental in taking up arms against German imperialism in defence of Namibian land and territorial integrity in many colonial foreign occupation resistance wars.

1.3. According to history and oral documentaries, he fled from his house at Gibeon with members of his army to Aminus after receiving news that the German army would be coming for the Nama people. Upon realizing his location could be compromised, he moved with his army towards Vaalgras. He was killed on 29 October 1905 by a single gunshot wound by the Germans on the northern plains of Vaalgras in the ||Kharas Region.

1.4. After discussion and debate in the House, the motion was subsequently referred to the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Human Resources and Community Development for further scrutiny and report back to the Assembly.

2. TERMS OF REFERENCE (TOR)

The specific objectives of the Motion were to;

2.1. To solicit views and opinions of the relevant stakeholders on the proposal to erect a shrine in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi at Vaalgras.

2.2. To determine whether the proposed site to construct the shrine is agreeable to the regional leadership and the Vaalgras and Gibeon communities.

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1. The Standing Committee decided to consult the Regional Leadership, Traditional Authorities, Royal Family, affected communities, and relevant institutions for their input to determine and cause of the erection of a shrine befitting the stature of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi at Vaalgras from 27-31 May 2024 in the Hardap and ||Kharas Regions.

3.2. Amongst the stakeholders consulted were: The Regional Governors and Regional Councillors of the Hardap and ||Kharas Regions, the Nama Traditional Leaders Association (NTLA), Witbooi Royal House, Vaalgras Traditional Authority and community members from Gibeon and Vaalgras.

3.3. The Committee was accompanied by officials from the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture, National Museum of Namibia and the National Heritage Council to offer technical advice.

3.4. At the meetings, Members of the Committee briefed participants and stakeholders on the purpose of the consultations and participants presented their views on the proposal to erect an ever-lighting shrine for Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi.

4. HARDAP REGION

4.1. The delegation met with the Regional Governor and Regional Councillors at Mariental to hear opinions and contributions regarding the Motion. They were of the view that the shrine be erected in Gibeon instead of Vaalgras. They explained that by putting up the shrine in the home village of Kaptein Witbooi it would make the people associated with the life of their hero. It will also significantly boost the local economy through tourism.

4.2. The construction, maintenance and operation of the shrine will create employment opportunities for the local people. Tourists visiting the shrine will purchase local goods and souvenirs, promote local markets and boost trade activities. The shrine can also serve as a centre for educational purposes, and traditional arts and crafts, and will provide income for the local community and promote cultural preservation. Additionally, they stressed that the shrine should be accompanied by a development of a structure such as a museum which will serve as an interactive space for heritage preservation and education.

4.3. **Witbooi Royal House**

(i) Members of the Witbooi Royal House were also of the view that the shrine should be erected at Gibeon because it sanctifies a holy place for its association with the life of their leader. It will bring a great deal of peace and comfort, as well as serve as a reminder of the heroism of their Auta !Nanseb.

(ii) They informed the Committee that every time a monument was constructed at Vaalgras it would collapse, making them believe it happened because it's a sacred history and they don't want to interfere with that place. They fear that the hand of God will be coming **to** them.

4.4. **Witbooi Traditional Authority and Community Members at Gibeon**

(i) The Witbooi Traditional Authority said although the historical ties between the people of Vaalgras and the IHowesin can never be separated, it can only be fair enough that a shrine is erected in Gibeon which is his birthplace and the seat of the lHowesin clan. The traditional authority further recommended that a befitting monument be constructed at Vaalgras to mark the place where Kaptein Witbooi passed on. They concluded by saying that both two places befitting Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi with a shrine and a monument.

(ii) The community members agreed with the traditional authority and proposed that the shrine be built at the homestead of the late Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi behind the Lutheran church. They believe the construction of the shrine will create jobs and uplift their socio-economic well-being.

(iii) Additionally, the traditional authority is in agreement with the community and proposed that the government take responsibility for rehabilitating and preserving the historical fountain in Gibeon as it is the source of their livelihood and has the potential to generate income for the community.

5. //KHARAS REGION

5.1. In the ||Kharas Region, both the Regional Leaders and Traditional Authorities concurred with their fellow leaders in the Hardap Region that the shrine of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi, Outa !Nanseb be erected in Gibeon where his roots are.

5.2. They said as much as Kaptein Witbooi was a national hero, he came from a certain background. They informed the Committee that in the culture of the Nama people no matter where you died, the remains must be returned to the ancestors, in this case, the person has to go back to where he or she came from. They also proposed that a monument be erected in Vaalgras where the Kaptein made his ultimate sacrifice of paying with his life for Namibia's liberation.

5.3. They said erecting a shrine in Gibeon in honour of the late Kaptein would add value to the rich history of the Witbooi clan and Namibia as a whole. It will also show that Namibians have not forgotten about their liberation struggle heroes.

5.4. **Vaalgras Traditional Authority and Community Members**

(i) The Vaalgras Traditional Authority said when the history of Outa !Nanseb is written one day and it omits that he was wounded and died in Vaalgras, such history would be incomplete. The traditional authority said they have no objection to the shrine being erected in Gibeon, they are in support of it but have requested that the government also construct a proper monument at Vaalgras since the two places equally share the same rich history.

(ii) The community of Vaalgras has welcomed the motion proposing the erection of an ever-lighting shrine in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi at their village. At the same time, they said they respected the IHowese clan's desire if they wanted to have the shrine erected at departed Gaob's homestead in Gibeon.

(iii) They, however, proposed the erection of a monument depicting Kaptein Witbooi riding his horse at the site called Witbooi's Einde, where he made his ultimate sacrifice. This, they argued, would bolster the existing historical ties between the two clans. The community plans to transform the site into a tourist attraction. Witbooi's Einde was declared a national heritage site in the year 2021.

5.5. **Nama Traditional Leaders Association (NTLA)**

(i) The NTLA welcomed the motion to erect the ever-lighting shrine, and like others, proposed that it be erected in Gibeon. They stressed that Kaptein Witbooi was not the only prominent figure within their communities, saying that there were other Chiefs who were also instrumental in taking up arms against German imperialism in defence of Namibian land and territorial integrity.

(ii) They advised that the fallen Chiefs should also be remembered and their names inscribed on the envisaged shrine and the monument.

6. FINDINGS

The Committee found that the overwhelming majority of the leaders and communities in Hardap and //Kharas Regions were in agreement that the befitting shrine in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi be erected at Gibeon where he hailed from. They also agreed that a befitting monument be constructed at Vaalgras where he made his ultimate sacrifice.

7. CONCLUSION

7.1. During the consultations, it came out that the majority of the communities understood and appreciated Kaptein Witbooi's sacrifices and colonial resistance, which motivated many people to join the fight to free their motherland.

7.2. Both the leaders and their communities welcomed the proposal to erect the shrine in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi and agreed that such a shrine and a monument will serve as an educational hub where social justice principles are not just celebrated, but also critically examined and reconstructed.

8. RECOMMENDATIONS

The Standing Committee recommends as follows:

8.1. That following the wishes of the people of Hardap and //Kharas Regions, in particular the communities of Gibeon and Vaalgras, that a befitting Shrine in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi be erected at Gibeon and not at Vaalgras.

8.2. That by the wishes of the people of Hardap and //Kharas Regions, in particular, the communities of Gibeon and Vaalgras, a befitting Monument in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi be constructed at Vaalgras.

8.3. Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture and the National Heritage Council of Namibia to provide a budget for the erection of a befitting shrine in honour of Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi at Gibeon.

8.4. To provide a budget for the construction of a museum at Gibeon to preserve history and teachings for Kaptein Witbooi's and other leaders' resistance to German oppression.

8.5. To provide a budget for the construction of a befitting monument depicting Kaptein Witbooi at Witbooi's Einde at Vaalgras.

8.6. To make budgetary provision to restore and declare the following historical places in Gibeon as heritage sites; Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi Homestead, Museum, Fountain, and the ELCIN Church.

8.7. Ensure that the names of fallen national heroes/heroines who fought alongside Kaptein Hendrik Witbooi are inscribed on the shrine and the monument.

8.8. That the erection and construction of the shrine and monument be done in full consultation and involvement of the regional leadership, traditional authorities, and the Witbooi Royal House.

9. SIGNATURE

04/03/25

Hon. Nono Katjingisiua, MP
Committee Chairperson

Date